

BUREAU OF INDIAN STANDARDS

Standard Operating Procedure for Assaying and Hallmarking Centres (AHCs)

1. SCOPE

These SOPs stipulate the procedure for the operation of Assaying and Hallmarking Centres. These are to be read in conjunction with BIS Act 2016, BIS Rules 2018, BIS (Hallmarking) Regulations 2018 and relevant Indian Standards as amended from time to time.

2. MANAGEMENT REQUIREMENTS

2.1 Management of the AHC shall ensure to carry out assaying and hallmarking activities within the scope of the recognition in such a way as to meet the requirements of, these SOPs, of BIS Act, 2016, BIS Rules, 2018, BIS(Hallmarking) Regulations, 2018, relevant Indian Standards, guidelines issued by BIS and to satisfy the needs of the customer and the regulatory authorities.

2.2 AHC must have insurance cover for the sum assessed on the basis of the value of jewellery received for hallmarking in a month.

2.3 Management of the AHC shall define and document the organization policy, objectives and roles and responsibilities of key personnel.

2.4 Management of the AHC shall conduct a review of the centre's assaying and hallmarking activities to ensure their continuing suitability and effectiveness as per planned schedule and procedure, and to introduce necessary changes or improvements

2.5 AHC shall not refuse to accept jewellery from any registered jeweller.

2.6 AHC shall follow FIFO (First in First out) principle on the basis of actual jewellery received, in testing of jewellery received from registered jeweller.

2.7 AHC shall give first priority to the lots of 10 numbers of jewellery articles of same purity received from Jewelers.

3. INFRASTRUCTURE REQUIREMENTS

3.1 AHC should be established as per the siting policies/guidelines of local administration.

3.2 AHC shall take the necessary clearance from local administration including Fire safety clearance.

3.3 AHC shall obtain the necessary consent from State Pollution Control Board in accordance with the Guidelines issued by CPCB.

3.4 AHC shall have adequate space for efficient functioning and for providing a safe and healthy working environment.

3.5 There shall be effective separation between neighboring areas viz. Reception, XRF, Sampling, Fire Assay and Laser Printing.

3.6 AHC shall maintain a display board near the entrance indicating the name, address, recognition number, validity period of recognition, and Hallmarking charges.

3.7 AHC shall have security system with closed circuit TV/motion picture detection system or any other suitable mechanism for the security of jewellery articles/artefacts received during day time or held overnight. The CCTV cameras shall be functional on 24x7 basis and the complete records of the footage be kept intact for at least one month. All the activities carried out in AHC shall be clearly recorded by the CCTV cameras. Record of the periods during which the CCTV camera at a location did not work and the reason thereof shall be maintained along with the record of footage.

3.8 The AHC shall ensure that the same Laser Marker is not used for any printing other than hallmarking.

3.9 Security of all the jewellery articles/artefacts shall be ensured during working hours and articles held overnight. Availability of safe to be ensured for secured storage of articles.

3.10 AHC shall provide Security Guard near the entrance of the AHC for safety of jewellery brought by jeweller representative.

4. MANPOWER REQUIREMENTS

4.1 AHC shall ensure that all staff are adequately qualified and experienced to perform the duties assigned to them with respect to their position.

4.2 AHC should endeavour to ensure that the person employed as the Fire Assay Master has completed the Certificate Course on Hallmarking run by NITS, Noida. It shall be mandatory, however, for the AHCs running more than one shift to have one of their Fire Assay Master having undergone this Certificate Course.

4.3 The AHC shall maintain current job descriptions for managerial, technical and key support personnel involved in assaying and hallmarking. A list of manpower preferably in the following format should be maintained:

S.No.	Section	Name of Employee	Role	Qualification	Experience	Training Received	Employed since	Monthly remuneration
-------	---------	------------------	------	---------------	------------	-------------------	----------------	----------------------

4.3 AHC shall employ the personnel after thoroughly checking the back ground of each of them and get their police verification done

4.4 AHC shall ensure that the personnel of the centre observe professional secrecy.

4.5 If the AHC runs in multiple shifts, the record shall be maintained regarding the number of shifts, duration of the each shift and manpower deployed per shift.

4.6 AHC shall document and inform BIS whenever there has been any change in technical manpower or Centre's Management since previous assessment. BIS auditor shall verify competency of changed manpower by actual work performance and report.

5. TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

5.1 The AHC shall have all the equipment of required accuracy/least count as per relevant Indian Standard to perform assaying and hallmarking. A list of equipment for assaying and hallmarking preferably in the following format should be maintained by the AHC.

S.No	Name of Equipment	Manufacturer name	Brand name	Model /Type/Make	Serial Number of equipment	Quantity	Range	Least count	Calibration done on	Calibration valid upto	Traceability	Date of purchase	Compatibility with AHC software	Remarks if any
------	-------------------	-------------------	------------	------------------	----------------------------	----------	-------	-------------	---------------------	------------------------	--------------	------------------	---------------------------------	----------------

5.2 All equipment and reference material required for correct performance of tests shall be maintained, verified and calibrated.

5.3 The calibration of equipment should be through NABL accredited laboratory, however, if calibration has been done by non-NABL accredited laboratory, the certificate of the calibration issued must be traceable to national standards.

5.4 AHC shall ensure that certified reference materials (CRMs) with purity certificate from Indian Govt. Mint or NABL accredited lab are used for checking XRF machine

5.5 AHC shall have the equipment suitable for the smooth operation of all the functionalities of the AHC software.

5.6 a) AHC shall ensure that the Machinery/equipment specifically XRF machine, weighing balances and Laser Machine shall have the capability so as to enable direct data transfer to centralized software for operation of Assaying & Hallmarking Centre.

b) Each of the XRF machines and Laser Marking Machines used for hallmarking must have the in-built software for integration with the AHC software.

c) The in-built software of the Laser marking Machine must have the feature to block the selection of a HUID after it has been selected once for printing, and an undertaking to this effect shall be furnished to the DDGR concerned.

5.6 All the major equipment should be operated by the personnel authorized for the purpose.

6. PROCESS/ SYSTEM REQUIREMENTS

6.1 AHC must use the software provided by BIS for Assaying and Hallmarking, as improved from time to time and ensure that the manpower engaged by the AHC is proficient enough to use software.

6.2 AHC shall ensure that identification and traceability of jewellery is maintained at all stages from receipt to delivery. The software feature for automatic tag generation may be used for the purpose.

6.3 AHC shall ensure that jewellery with prohibited markings is not accepted for hallmarking.

6.4 AHC shall maintain the records of receipt, consumption and testing of reference materials ensuring identification and traceability.

6.5 AHC shall ensure that the jewellery/artefacts are hallmarked and kept ready for delivery to the client within 48 hrs.

6.6 AHC shall take insurance for the jewellery/artefacts under process/stock and high cost equipment for minimum amount of Rs. 10 lakh. The insurance amount shall be increased in proportion to the amount of jewellery received by AHC.

6.7 AHC shall ensure the protection of its customer's confidential information and proprietary rights.

6.8 AHC shall have procedure to maintain confidentiality of the design of the jewellery received for hallmarking or any other information pertaining to jeweler.

6.9 AHC shall have quality control procedures for monitoring the validity of tests undertaken.

6.10 AHC shall maintain the integrity of the assaying and hallmarking process as laid down in IS 15820: 2009.

6.11 AHC shall return cornets of the tested articles to the jeweller at the time of returning the hallmarked items.

6.12 AHC shall retain the proof assay gold cornets with proper identification and traceability for last 30 assaying.

6.13 AHC shall ensure that sampling of gold jewellery articles is done as per the sampling plan of IS 15820: 2009 with minimum possible damage to the jewellery.

6.14 AHC shall follow the sampling plan given in IS 15820 (specially of mix lot) and relevant records shall be maintained.

6.15 AHC shall ensure that markings on the article are legible and done on all removable / detachable parts in the defined sequence.

6.16 AHC shall ensure any gold/silver article/ornament which is not solid or which is made with hollow centre and then filled with cement, lac or other foreign substance which is non-metallic will be additionally marked with the weight of gold or silver (as applicable) as declared by the registered jeweller.

6.17 AHC shall participate in inter laboratory comparison or proficiency testing programmes. Quality control data shall be analyzed and where they are found to be outside pre-defined criteria, planned action shall be taken to correct the problem and to prevent incorrect results from being reported.

6.18 AHC shall ensure that it is working within the approved scope for recognition obtained from BIS.

6.19 AHC shall handover the cornets of samples assayed lot at the time for delivery of hallmarked articles to jeweller.